The locals were not pleased at the intrusion, and several years of destructive fighting followed. Finally the Mexica were beaten into submission, turned into slaves and servants. The surrounding tribes divided the defeated newcomers up; the largest group of Mexica was claimed by the king of Colhuacan, the city nearest to their hill, as his vassals. The Mexica had fought fiercely against their attackers, and their new master intended to use them as front-line troops in future wars.

As he didn't really care whether or not they survived, he settled them in a barren plain south of his city; it was called Tizapan, and it was filled with rocks and poisonous snakes. But the Mexica were tough, and they survived in their inhospitable new land. For decades, they bided their time, serving the king of Colhuacan, building their strength.[2]

Around 1325, they made an unmistakable gesture of defiance and independence. They told their royal master, the king Achitometl, that they wished to elevate his daughter, the princess of Colhuacan, to goddesshood, and asked that she be sent to them so that they could carry out the rituals.

The king agreed, and the princess was taken with great ceremony out to the highest point of Tizapan. An oral tradition, set down in the sixteenth century by the Spanish courtier Fernando Alvarado Tezozómoc, tells the rest of the story:

> Then they slew the princess and they flayed her,
> and after they flayed her, they dressed a priest in her skin.

Then they summoned her father, King Achitometl, to come and greet the goddess. Achitometl gathered up flowers and food to offer his daughter, and the Mexica led him into the darkened interior of their sacred building. He set the offerings down in front of the indistinct figure, but

> he still did not see the person . . .
> Then he made an offering of incense and the incense-burner blazed up,
> and Achitometl saw a man in his daughter's skin.
> He was horror-struck.
> He cried out, he shouted to his lords and to his vassals . . .
> "They have flayed my daughter!
> They shall not remain here, the fiends!
> We shall slay them, we shall massacre them! The evil ones
> shall be annihilated here!"[3]

He set his warriors against the Mexica, and they were driven away from